

Q&A Session – April 28th, 2026

14:00-14:30 BKK, ZOOM

Global Hackathon on AI for Digital Trade Regulatory Analysis – held by UN ESCAP & KMITL

Summary of the session

1. Scope, users, and what to build

1.1 Who are the target users?	Primary: ESCAP RDTII researchers, especially in the Asia-Pacific region (the people doing the manual workflow on slide 4). Secondary: policymakers and analysts in member-state ministries. Both non-technical — no code, no JSON. Implication: the 20% human-review step must be obvious in the UI, not buried.
1.2 What level of analysis / detail is expected?	Article-level granularity — each output points to a specific article in a specific document, with all 6 mandatory fields (title, last update, URL, scope, provisions, impact). A reviewer must verify or reject any mapping in seconds. Document-level summaries fail at the citation-fidelity benchmark at Stage 2.
1.3 Would an NTM classification solution be suitable?	Not directly. Mandatory pillars are 6 (Cross-border Data Flows) + 7 (Domestic Data Protection); broad NTM is out of scope. Works only if your NTM approach is redirected to extract digital trade provisions or provisions related to ICT goods specifically. Pillars 6 and 7 are non-negotiable; everything else is design choice.
1.4 Could you clarify the overall scope?	Build a deployable open-source AI tool (Apache 2.0) that automates 80% of the RDTII workflow on slide 5 — search, retrieve, describe — leaving 20% for human validation. Mandatory: Pillars 6 and 7. Bonus: tools that scale to additional pillars. Geographic coverage: Your tool should show that it works for multiple Asia-Pacific countries (see Q 5.4).

2. Originality, prior work, innovation vs practicality

2.1 Can we build on existing solutions?	Yes — open-source libraries, pre-trained models, and licensed components are allowed. Originality means contribution, not invention. Hard constraints: licenses must be Apache-2.0-compatible AND your system must work when components are swapped. Disclose all reused components in the Technical Memo.
2.2 Can existing systems be submitted?	Build on prior work: yes. Submit unchanged: no — must show meaningful new development for this challenge. If your starting point is substantial for pre-existing internal work, contact organizers before applying. Final repo ships under Apache 2.0 either way.
2.3 Innovation vs practicality?	Practicality dominates — ~70% of Stage 3 score is deployment, interface, generalisation, and live stress test. Innovation earns leverage where it delivers measurable results: 20 points at Stage 2 for Discovery of New Evidence. Optimise for "does it work, cheaply, repeatably, on unseen jurisdictions?"
2.4 What about IP rights?	Under the Apache License 2.0, individual contributors retain the copyright/intellectual property (IP) rights to their original contributions. However, by licensing the work under Apache 2.0, these owners grant a perpetual, worldwide, non-exclusive, free-

	of-charge, irrevocable license to anyone to use, modify, and distribute the software.
3. Evaluation, judging, and recognition	
3.1 How is scoring structured?	Three stages, each with a published rubric. Weights shift design → delivery → production-readiness. Stage 1 is two-thirds of team capability and methodology (no code yet). Stage 3 emphasizes readiness for real UN deployment.
3.2 What does each stage measure?	Stage 1 (Application): Team expertise 40% / Methodology 30% / Sustainability 30%. Stage 2 (Round 1): Substantive accuracy 40% / Technical resilience 30% / Architecture 30%. Stage 3 (Finale): autonomous generalization, interface, deployment, live stress test on unseen countries.
3.3 Who judges?	International panel: ESCAP, regional commissions, UNCTAD, WTO, World Bank, academic partners. COI (conflict of interest) rule: no judging teams you're in, supervise, mentor, or have financial ties with. Written COI declarations from all judges; best-effort screening of assignments.
4. Application, teams, and process	
4.1 Key dates / submission deadline?	Apply by 31 May 2026, 17:00 Bangkok / 10:00 UTC (only deadline before shortlist). Shortlist 15 June → Round 1 submission 20 July → hybrid pitch 31 July → finalists 1 August → final submission 30 September → award ceremony at ESCAP Bangkok, 15 October 2026. Further information will be provided to shortlisted candidates.
4.2 Will templates be provided?	Yes — Concept Video brief, Technical Memo template, Declaration of Originality, is available on the website. Funding-partner matchmaking: NO. No development funding, no API credits, no compute, no sponsor-matching service.
4.3 Application items + formatting?	Four items: CVs of all members; Concept Video (max 5 min including credits); Technical Memo (max 2 pages — reviewers read first 2 only, diagrams count); signed Declaration of Originality + Apache 2.0 consent. English only. Cost estimate per 50-page doc must be in the Memo. No late submissions except documented platform failure.
4.4 Eligibility?	Open globally — students, faculty, researchers, professionals, any nationality. Teams can mix across universities, countries, and student/professional status. Multiple teams per institution allowed, no cap. Only rule: dual-competency (Technical + Substantive Lead). ESCAP interns and consultants are welcome as long as there are no conflict of interests.
4.5 Team structure?	1–5 members. Technical Lead (AI architecture, extraction, deployment) + Substantive Lead (legal/policy, output accuracy). Soloists allowed but must hold both Lead roles and prove dual competency at Stage 1 (high bar). Faculty: full member OR advisor — not both.
4.6 collaboration platform?	Organizer-to-team: Q&A Portal + SharePoint Resource Library. Within your team: you choose your own tools — we don't prescribe. Inter-team open channel: linked to the matchmaking decision (likely Discord/LinkedIn).
5. Tech stack, fine-tuning, datasets, funding	
5.1 What tech stack is allowed?	Anything during development — paid LLM APIs (Claude, GPT, Gemini) fine. But: design must be modularly swappable to open-weight models (e.g. Llama 3) — scored heavily, 20 pts at Stage 1 + 20 at Stage 3. Open-source components OK if Apache-2.0-compatible; disclose all in Memo.

5.2 Fine-tune open-weight models?	Yes. Fine-tuning allowed; resulting weights are part of the submission. Base model license must be Apache-2.0-compatible (Llama 3 family OK; Mistral with care). Fine-tuned weights must be published in the GitHub repo , not kept private. Disclose training data and method in the Memo.
5.3 Recommended AI tools / prompting?	No prescription — design choices are scored. Patterns that work well: RAG over OCR'd legal text with article-level chunking + structured prompting for citation extraction + small classifiers for indicator mapping with LLM verification. Whatever you pick, prove generalisation and document the cost.
5.4 Datasets / technical requirements?	Application stage: ESCAP website contains RDTII-related database and guide which can be used to train and test your system (Structure of Analysis ESCAP ; Regional Digital Trade Integration Index (RDTII) 2.1: a guide ESCAP). However, your tool should prove that you can find new evidence beyond what is provided. At this stage, there is no fixed coverage regarding countries. Round 1: 5–10 documents from 3 provided countries + reference taxonomy in the Resource Library. Finale: 10 assigned countries (some non-English, some with messy portals — anti-bot, scanned PDFs), deliver for at least 3 countries . Tool requirements: open-source, modular, OCR <5% CER, audit view, self-hostable.
6. Mentorship, support, finale logistics	
6.1 How accessible are mentors?	Asynchronous via Q&A Portal — target ~2 business days normally, 1 near deadlines. Mentors are a panel responding to portal queries and running scheduled office hours around milestones — not assigned 1:1 , no live always-on chat. Plan accordingly.
6.2 What ongoing support?	Q&A Portal (help desk and discussion forum) + Resource Library on SharePoint (RDTII framework, reference taxonomy with semantic patterns, sample documents, sample portals, templates). Plus 11 hours of structured training across two workshops: ESCAP 5 June + KMITL 10 June 2026.
6.3 Bangkok finale logistics?	Travel grant up to USD 4,000 per finalist team — single pool regardless of where members fly from, ≤3 sponsored travellers, reimbursed against receipts. Visa invitation letters issued on request. Accommodation reimbursable. Accessibility accommodations require 4 weeks' notice — request as soon as finalists are announced (1 August).

Recording available at: [Global Hackathon on Using AI for Digital Trade Regulatory Analysis | ESCAP](#)

Other useful links:

KMITL Event Page: [digitaltradehack2026 - ENGINEER](#)

ESCAP Event Page: [Global Hackathon on Using AI for Digital Trade Regulatory Analysis | ESCAP](#)

Registration Link: [Global Hackathon Using AI for Digital Trade Regulatory Analysis – Application Form](#)

Regional Digital Trade Integration Index (RDTII) is the framework for the competition:

RDTII Framework: [Structure of Analysis | ESCAP](#)

RDTII Guide: [Regional Digital Trade Integration Index \(RDTII\) 2.1: a guide | ESCAP](#)

Contact: If you have any further queries, drop us an email at escap-digitaltrade-hackathon@un.org and regtech2026@kmitl.ac.th.